

CLOSE RANKS Policemen in front of the Madhya Pradesh Vidhan Sabha

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▶ MADHYA PRADESH

MARCHING TO THE DECEPTION BEAT

The fraud in MP Police's selection test for constables shows the practice still thrives in the land of Vyapam scam

By **Rahul Noronha**

THE INFAMOUS VYAPAM SCAM, which had once grown like weed over the state recruitment process, has just had a baby—in the digital age. The shadow of corruption this time is on a selection test held in 2023 to conscript fresh constables into Madhya Pradesh Police. As is usual in India, there were 7,411 posts and more than 950,000 applicants. So it seems the cannier ones among those who aspired to be footsoldiers of the law broke the law in the first instance, allegedly using impersonation, tampered documents and sophisticated biometric swaps.

The modus operandi was a time-honoured one, but with a contemporary twist. Impersonators would take the written test. Since identity had to be confirmed through Aadhaar, the photograph and fingerprints of applicants were replaced with those of the 'solvers'—who would make a neat Rs 4-5 lakh in the process. The Aadhaar biometrics would then go back to the original settings, for the physical test. Here, the lazier ones became the weak link: having outsourced the written part, they began looking for proxies to take the physical test as well. Word reached the recruitment wing of the MP police, investigations began, and everything unravelled.

Takeaways

- **The scam in the selection test for constables involves impostor 'solvers' taking tests with forged Aadhaar cards**
- **The MP Police has made 12 arrests; 20 FIRs have been filed, and there are more than 100 suspects**

The haul so far: around 20 FIRs across the state, 12 arrests and more than 100 suspects, including some attached to kiosks that do online application work. One arrest is that of an ace solver from Bihar who had cracked five papers for six candidates—no cloud, therefore, on the job he had himself landed in 2024 as a school teacher in Bihar. But he typifies the scam's suspected sprawl, extending to Jharkhand, Delhi and Uttar Pradesh, say police. Locally, most suspects are from the Gwalior-Chambal region, which has become synonymous with recruitment scams. It had had a starring role during Vyapam, and has apparently never forgotten its skills. ■